Business Communication

Week 2 Worksheet: Internal vs External Communication

Case Study: NextGen Software

You have just started an internship at NextGen Software, an ICT company that develops mobile applications and cloud-based business solutions. During your first week, you will work with developers, managers, customer support staff and marketing employees. Complete the activities below by thinking carefully about the audience and the purpose of each communication.

Your IT Project Manager will give you several communication tasks. In each activity, think carefully about **who is communicating, who the audience is, the purpose of the communication, and how the message should be adapted for that audience.**

Part A – Internal or External Communication

Decide whether each situation is an INTERNAL or EXTERNAL communication.

Situation	Internal, External or both?	Why?
Developers discuss a software bug.	internal/Both.	Only employees involved. benefit users.
The HR department announces a new company policy.	internal	~~An~~ Announcement is for all employees.
Customer Support replies to a client about a problem.	external	External individue request information from company.
The company announces a new mobile app update.	external/Both.	A features for all the customers.
The Project Manager shares meeting minutes.	internal	Only employees involved.
The CEO announces the company's annual goals.	Both	~~Encourage~~ investor. and specific goal for employees.
The Marketing Department prepares information for customers.	external/Both	It could be for customer. and also for customer Support department.

Part B – Audience, Tone and Formality

Complete the table. Think about how the audience affects the way the message should be written. In some cases, more than one level of formality is possible.

Situation	Audience	Formal/ semi-formal/ Informal
Software bug report	Developers on your project team	~~Da~~ Semi-formal
Company policy announcement	Employees who are sent a message by the HR department	Formal / Informal
Customer complaint	A customer who receives a reply from customer support after a complaint	X Formal
Product update	Customers who receive a public announcement from the company	Formal
Weekly project report	The manager who is updated on the project status by your team	Semi-formal / informal.

Part C – Audience Analysis

Scenario: NextGen Software has discovered a security issue affecting its mobile application. The application will be unavailable on Saturday from 9:00–11:00 a.m. while the issue is fixed.

Your IT Project Manager asks you to help prepare communication about the issue for three different audiences: software developers, company managers and customers.

Before preparing the messages, analyze what information each audience needs.

Complete the table. Decide what each audience needs to know and what information would be unnecessary or inappropriate for them.

Audience	What will this audience be most concerned about?	What do they need to know?	What information should not be included?
Software Developers	Details above the isuss. The deadline of the ~~task~~.	The information about the isuss and ~~when needs~~ deadline.	Customer complain. Pressure from stakeholder.
Company Managers	~~the~~ How long does it take to solve the isuss?	up-to-date information about ~~software team's~~ isuss progress.	Technical details.
Customers	When will the application be available?	The time when the application back to service/online.	Technical details.

Part D – Evaluating Business Messages

Read external messages A and B, and evaluate them using the table on the next page

Message A

Subject: App Problem

Dear Customer,

Our app has a security problem, so it won't work on Saturday morning. We are fixing it as quickly as possible. Sorry for the inconvenience.

Thank you.

NextGen Software

Message B

Subject: Scheduled Maintenance Notice

Dear Customers,

We would like to inform you that our mobile application will be temporarily unavailable on Saturday from 9:00 a.m. until 11:00 a.m. due to scheduled maintenance to improve the security of our system.

During this time, you will not be able to access the application or complete any transactions. Our technical team is working to ensure that all services return to normal as quickly as possible.

We apologize for any inconvenience this may cause. If you require assistance, please contact our Customer Support team.

Thank you for your patience and understanding.

Kind regards,
NextGen Software

Criteria	Message A	Message B	Which is better? Why?
Purpose is clear	No	Yes	A doesn't ~~and~~ include much information. B provides details ~~and~~.
Information is complete	Yes	Yes	B provides more info, such as why, and when,
Tone is appropriate	No	Yes	B ~~wes~~ uses more polite ~~wor~~ vocabulary.
Easy to understand	Yes	~~Yes~~ No	A is easier to understand, but unclear.
Includes important details	No	Yes	B includes every details.

Part E – Planning a Message for Company Managers

Your IT Project Manager asks you to help plan an internal update for company managers about the security issue described in Part C.

Use your answers from Part C to plan the message. Do not write the complete message yet.

Answer the following Planning Messages:

1. What is the main purpose of the message?
   repore the isuss to stakeholder.

2. What are the 3 most important points the manager should know?
   How long does it take to fix?
   What's the impact to business?
   Can the software team fix it on time?
3. What action do you recommend the managers should take after reading it?
   Evaluate the situation, inform the customer service team.
   Make sure software team is working on ie, and report to the stakeholder.
4. What concerns might managers have about this situation?
   Will it takes longer time than expected to fix?
   Is this the only isuss we have?
5. How can your message help managers feel confident that the situation is under control?
   Explain the isuss ~~the~~ brifely and what action team are taking.

6. In what order would you present the information?
   First, the problem we occured; second, ~~the details of~~ a brief report of the issus;
   Third, the impact and the estimated fix time.
7. Should the tone be formal, informal, or semi-formal? Explain your answer
   Has to be formal, because, this is a serious matter,
   time is the most valuable resource here, so we
   should keep the communication efficiene.

Part F – Planning a Message for Software Developers

Your IT Project Manager also asks you to help plan an internal message for the Software Development Team. You need to communicate with the **Software Development Team** about the security issue described in Part C.

Use your answers from Part C to plan an internal message. **Do not write the message yet.**

Answer the following Planning Messages:

1. What is the main purpose of the message?
   Provide nessary information to help them tackle the problem.
2. What are the 3 most important points the developers should know?
   When the issue occured? what was the intend purpose?
   ~~What~~ Is/Was it affect happened once only, or multiple times?
3. What action do you recommend the software developers should take after reading it?
   Investigate, plan, and solve it.
4. What concerns might developers have about this situation?
   The report lacks details, and cause more time spended to investigate.
5. How can your message help developers understand what they need to do?
   Give them information to make reasonable action
6. How should you organize the information?
   Format the message in linear sequence, use time to specify the event.
7. Should the tone be formal, informal, or semi-formal? Explain your answer
   semi-formal/ formal would be ok, since we need clear sentence, precise vocabulary, and well structured.

Part G – Write Your Message

Using your plans from **Part E and Part F**, choose **ONE** audience:

Company Managers **OR** Software Developers

Write the complete message you planned.

Before writing, make sure your message:

- has a clear purpose
- includes the information your audience needs.
- leaves out unnecessary information.
- uses an appropriate level of formality and tone.
- is organized clearly.
- explains any action the audience needs to take.
- uses accurate and professional language.

Your Message:

Subject: ~~App Problem~~ xxx Application issuss.

Dear Software team;

We've received mulriple complains about the application crash down. Based on ~~our~~ customer service team, they provided a detailed report about this issuss, please check the attached file.

Furthermore, the manager team would like to know the estimate time to fix this problem, and is ie nesessery to schedule a maintance!

Please work on the problem once you received this email, the customer service team will handle the custome complain.

Best Regards.